

INNOVATIONS ▷

Earlier dresses had long tippetts cut as part of the sleeve and faced with fur. The white cloth streamers on this *cote-hardie* could be a successor to these.

Buttons were fashionable for both men and women: the most expensive, with precious stones, were made by goldsmiths; cheaper ones were cast in pewter.

The curved neckline is cut to sit low on the shoulders

White streamers are made of worsted cloth

FRONT VIEW



IN DETAIL



◁ BUTTONING TECHNIQUE

The buttons shown here are those used in the 14th century. Rather than being sewn, they are secured on to the dress with a single length of cord, a technique that was employed on similar dresses at the time.



◁ BUTTONHOLES

Buttonholes are hand-sewn using silk thread, and all unlined wool edgings of the dress are finished with silk facings. The dress buttons left-over-right, the same as men's clothes. The convention that women's clothing buttons right-over-left came much later.



◁ SINGLE LACE

The neckline is opened here to reveal the grey wool kirtle beneath, front-laced down the centre to hip level with a single lace, as was the practice in medieval times.



◁ EYELETS

Hand-stitched eyelets are set close together and tight to the garment's edge so the lacing is discreet and functional.



◁ SELF-COVERED BUTTONS

The sleeves of the kirtle narrow to long cuffs fastened with up to 50 self-cloth buttons, each one made from a circle of fabric sewn tightly to form a firm ball. These long cuffs would have been impractical for anyone who had to do manual work.



◁ OPENED CUFF

An unbuttoned cuff reveals a simple linen shift worn next to the skin. Wealth was reflected in the quality and number of shifts the wearer owned and how frequently they were changed and laundered.